The siren rang the loudest one day in September 1990. Prisoners were igniting LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) cylinders wrapped in blankets and placed against the security walls to blast holes in them. Thousands of male prisoners were trying to scale the walls of the women's barracks or break open the barracks' gates. The riot was quelled only when the Tamil Nadu Special Police Force opened fire, in which ten prisoners were killed. The reason for the riot was the claim by the prisoners that one of them had died because of gross medical neglect, in spite of their long-drawn-out and repeated appeals for medicare.

However, the situation had changed dramatically since then. The prisoners of Tihar appeared to have laid implicit trust and faith in the jail staff's attempts to make their lives more comfortable and to give them a new sense of direction. Kiran was sensitive to this aspect and so repeatedly reminded her staff:

> We must never forget our gratitude to the 9500 prisoners who have given us their hearts and who are the main dramatis personae in enabling us to achieve our goals. The cooperation, the discipline, the obedience which these inmates have extended to us, let us not ever forget. What we have done was merely our duty.
>
> The greatest change I perceive that has come about in this system is that you have transformed yourselves from security guards to time managers. You have taken on the responsibility of managing the lives of 9500 people by scheduling and directing their time towards constructive and satisfying goals. None bears a greater responsibility than you.

The staff apparently appreciated the efforts of a benevolent leadership, and the rapidity with which reforms took place in Tihar was a direct result of their cooperation and new sense of duty. In May 1993 Kiran inherited 127 vigilance cases, including a lot of suspensions and departmental enquiries. When she left the total number of cases was 31 with minimum suspensions. Each case was taken on its merits and those who deserved punishment for infringement and breaking of rules for selfish reasons spent time in prison. The others have been absolved.

The message given to the staff was very clear: 'Each case of infringement will be taken on individual merit. Anyone trying to perpetrate a fraud on this jail will not be suspended at all but will be immediately booked under the Prisons Act. The magisterial enquiry will be completed within a month and, if found guilty, the person will be dismissed from service immediately. No suspensions whatsoever. We will not permit such persons to continue to draw 80 per cent of their salaries and do a side business as well. That was a system practised in the past. We consider it wrong and we shall not follow it. We do not have the money to pay such people without their having to do their duty.'

'Just look at the enormity of the situation we faced,' pointed out a very perturbed Kiran. 'Prisons had no training pattern whatsoever. The jail came up in 1958 and would you believe it, since then, there has been no training manual, no school, no training centre, nothing. No training concept, no training wing, not even any training material. I am shocked. It is only now in recent times that two such regional institutes have come up: One in Chandigarh and one in Vellore [in Tamil Nadu].'

'But how could I send my staff there for training? I was already so understaffed here,' she queried. She then added: 'Still we were sending those we could.'

And yet efforts had to be made in this direction because training was central to the whole concept of running a prison as a correctional centre. So, an assistant superintendent's crash training course was commenced.

'As a first reaction to this course I was completely taken aback,' confessed Kiran. 'My men did not